

# **Field Report: Helping Immigrant Families Connect with Local Communities**

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### **Abstract**

This study is focus on the information and decision-making difficulties face by immigrant families in participate in local community activities. In multicultural society like Australia, community participation is of great significance for the integration and sense of belonging of immigrant families. But in actual situations, many families still find it difficult to effectively access and utilize relevant information. Previous literatures has shown that the presence of information alone is not sufficient to facilitate participation. Language proficiency, social trust, and understanding of the actual participation in activities can also have an impact on decision-making. This study adopts a mixed method to analyze the actual experiences of immigrant families in the process of "acquisition, understanding and decision-making" through 10 semi-structured interviews and 31 questionnaires. The findings indicate that immigrant families face a combination of challenges, including fragmented information, uncertainty in judging activity suitability, language-related communication pressure, and reliance on familiar social networks. These factors together make it difficult for users to move from knowing about an activity to actual participation. From the results, today's platforms focus more on presenting information, while their support for users in understanding, judging and building trust is still limited. Therefore, design needs to pay more attention to the participation process itself, rather than only focus on information presentation. This includes provide clearer activity descriptions and process expectations, enhance language support, introduce others' experiences and combine acquaintance networks for recommendations. These directions are closer to the real needs of users and also reflect the role of information design in promoting inclusivity.

## Summary of background literature

In multicultural countries like Australia, help immigrant families integrate into society is important not only for community cohesion but also for their own well-being. However, many new immigrants still face real difficulties when trying to access local information and take part in community activities. This is more prominent for families with young children, as children often act as “cultural bridges”, connecting the family to the wider social environment (Katz, 2014). Although schools and childcare centres can offer some initial connections, but parents often find it hard to move beyond informal social networks and develop a genuine sense of belonging.

**In this process, language is a key factor that shapes participation.** Previous studies suggest that language proficiency plays an important role in how immigrants adapt to the host society, and whether they take part in community and civic activities (Kuperman, 2022). **Because of this, researchers in HCI have started to explore how digital tools might support this process,** especially through co-design approaches. Some studies involve immigrants directly in the design process, resulting in tools that combine multilingual support and explanations of administrative procedures. These tools make those information easier to understand and help immigrants more close with their communities (Concilio et al., 2022).

**However, passive information presentation does not necessarily lead to actual participation.** Passive information display is often not enough to encourage real engagement. Recent studies show that immigrants rely heavily on trust within their personal networks when deciding whether to use information. Many people instead turn to “arrival brokers” or rely on recommendations from people they trust (Wessendorf, 2022; Hans, 2023). Hans (2023) also points out that earlier immigrants often share their own experiences, which helps new arrivals make up for the lack of accessible formal information. **This suggests that information alone is not sufficient, and that social context plays an important role in decision-making.** Therefore, incorporating real user experience into design may improve trust and willingness to use information.

**At the same time, another issue lies in how information is understood in context.** Many existing designs does not fully consider the uncertainty people face during interaction. Even when information is technically available, users may still struggle to understand and apply it. Because they are unfamiliar with the local system. This can affect their ability to make decisions about participation (Bahl et al., 2025). These kinds of barriers increase the effort required to make decisions, but are still not well addressed in current design.

With cultural diversity of Australia, **the impact of these issues becomes more visible.** Many immigrant families cannot turn available information into actual participation. This reduce their level of community engagement and affect their connection and social integration. In this sense, inclusive technology design is not only about usability, but also link to broader issues of social equity (Helsper, 2021).

Although existing research has increasingly focus on inclusive design, there is still limited attention to the uncertainty and situational understanding challenges that immigrant families face during the participation process. Much of the current work mainly looks at information accessibility and less to how users actually make sense of information in real situation.

This study aims to identify key barriers and examine how design can enhance trust and reduce uncertainty in the participation process, while also offering insights for how HCI can better support the social integration of immigrant families.

### **Investigation methods**

This study uses a mixed-methods approach. We combine semi-structured interview with an online survey and try to have a better understand that how immigrant families participate in local community activities. Such like what difficulties they face or what kinds of support they may need. We chose this mix-method because a single method would not be enough. Interviews will help us explore people's experiences and survey can give us actual data from a larger group. Using both methods makes the study more balanced and more reliable.

The main aim of this project is to explore user needs and find key problems. For this reason, the study is mainly qualitative, and the survey gives extra support. We first use semi-structured interviews. We want to learn how immigrant families find information about community activities, how they decide whether to join, and what they experience when they do join. We chose semi-structured interviews because this method gives the conversation some structure, but it also leaves room for follow-up questions. This is important for our project. We want to understand not only what people do, but also why they do it. Participants were recruited through convenience and snowball sampling, start with our social networks and expand through participant referrals.

We also use an online survey to collect data from a wider group of people. The survey received 31 valid responses. The survey asks about how long people have lived in Australia, their children's schooling, how often they join community activities, where they get information, what barriers they face, how confident they feel using English and what kinds of support may help them join more easily.

We also consider ethics throughout the study. Before people take part in the interview. We tell them the purpose of the project and how we will use their data. Participation is fully voluntary. People can refuse to answer any question. All data will be stored anonymously.

We will use different analysis methods for the two types of data. For the interview, thematic analysis will be use. We will read the interview responses several times. We will look for repeated ideas. Then we will group similar ideas into themes. For the survey data, we will use

descriptive statistics. We will look at frequencies and percentages. This will help us understand general patterns. The survey results will support the interview findings.

### **Finding**

This study conducted semi-structured interviews with 10 immigrant families and explored their experiences and challenges in participating in community activities. Data from 31 questionnaires were also used as quantitative support. To protect participants' privacy, P1 - P10 will be used throughout the finding part.

With thematic analysis, four key themes were identified:

1. Fragmented Information Access
2. Uncertainty in Participation Decision-Making
3. Language and Social Barriers
4. Reliance on Familiar Social Networks

#### **Fragmented Information Access**

Research has found that, immigrant families generally face the problem of information dispersion when search community activities information. The participant refers that, relevant information is distribute across multiple channels such as school, WeChat group, social media, government website and so on. There is lack a unified entrance.

P1 pointed that: "There is no way to know about these activities, I usually through school or friends."

P2 also mentioned: "The information is particularly scattered, and we won't specifically look for these activities."

Some participants (P7 and P10) also indicated that they are less or not use official platforms. The questionnaire show some further support. 67% of respondents mainly get information through friends. 60% of them rely on school. And only 20% use government websites. This result shows that community activities information mainly relies on informal channels dissemination and lack systematic integration. Users need to switch between multiple channels which might increase cognitive burden and reduce the likelihood of participation. This also reflects the shortcoming of current information systems in integration and user-oriented design.

#### **Uncertainty in Participation Decision-Making**

Another point is that, even the activities information is already show, there is still significant uncertainty for users when it comes to whether or not to participate. Participants generally have difficulty of judging the content, process and suitability of the activities for their own families.

P5 said: “I'm not quite sure what this activity is for, so I won't consider participate.”

P1 also mentioned that: “if doesn't understand the specific process, I may hesitate a bit.”

In addition, P6 and P7 pointed out that the activity description is relatively brief and difficult to support their judgment. According to questionnaire data, 30% of respondents believe that difficult to get clear process information is one of the biggest obstacles. And most people hope to obtain a clear activity description and some participation experiences from others.

This discovery indicates that the problem is not only whether the information exists, but also in whether it has “decision support”. There is a gap between information acquisition and behavioral decision-making. This account for exist platforms are more inclined towards information display and ignore users decision-making needs.

### **Language and Social Barriers**

Insufficient language proficiency is an important factor affect participation. And it will further trigger psychological pressure at the social level. Multiple participants expressed a lack of confidence and even avoided participate in communication.

For example, P3 pointed out: "My English is not very good, so I don't dare to communicate.”

P5 same: "When facing others, I can't speak up and feel very nervous.”

P8 further stated that even if already known what the activity is about, they may not choose to participate due to the communication pressure. Same with the questionnaire, 53% of respondents believe that language is the main barrier, while 53% lack confidence in interaction, and over 60% lack confidence in English communication. This proved that language problems are not only communication barriers, but can also translate into social anxiety, thereby inhibit actual participation behavior. This result is also consistent with previous literature on the impact of language ability on social participation.

### **Reliance on Familiar Social Networks**

The study also found that immigrant families highly rely on acquaintance networks when participating in community activities. Participants are more easily to participate in activities with the participation of acquaintances, but hold a cautious attitude towards unfamiliar environments.

For example, P3 means: "It's easier to participate with people you know.” P5 also mentioned, "If I have someone I known with me, I would be more willing to go.”

It happens that there is a similar case, P1, P2, and P10 all said that their participation behavior mostly comes from recommendations from friends or parents. The questionnaire data also shows that 67% of respondents rely on friends to obtain information.

This shows that “social security” is also an important factor driving participation. Although acquaintance networks greatly lower the threshold for participation, it may also limit users' access to a wider range of community resources.

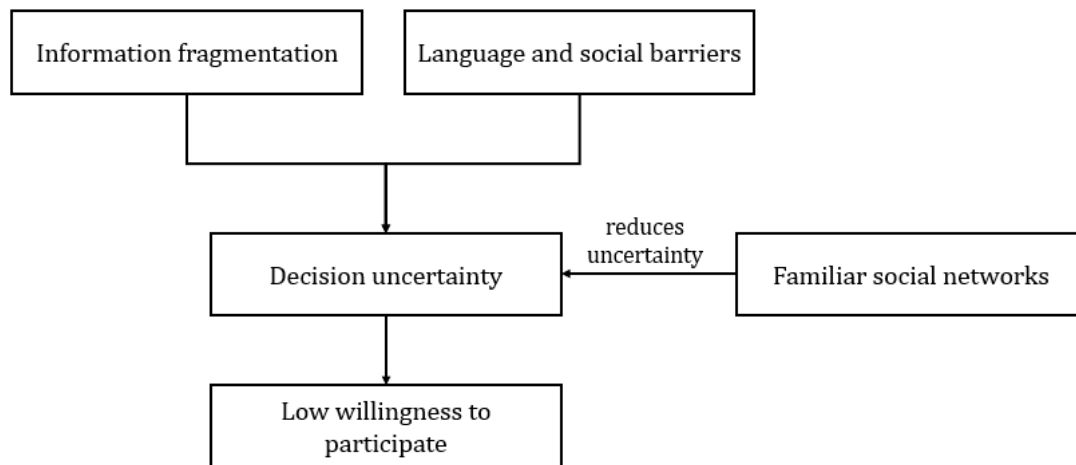


Figure 1. Conceptual model of immigrant families' participation in community activities

Overall, the obstacles face by immigrant families in participating in community activities are not a single factor. It combines multiple things such as information, cognition and socialization. These problems form a continuous chain of "information fragmentation, cognitive uncertainty and social barriers", gradually affect users' participation decisions and actual behaviors.

## Discussion

This study looks at how immigrant families find, understand, and use information about community activities. Through 10 semi-structured interviews and 31 online surveys, we find that immigrant families not only face one simple problem. They face a series of connect barriers. And these issues affect the whole process from known and exists to actually join.

Study find that participate in community not just about have information. Many say that after they see information, they still need think many things: what activity is, how it works, if it suits child, and if it's worth time. This show problem is not whether information exist, but whether it help make decision. Access to info is not same as usable info. This aligns with Bahl et al. (2025). They show people still struggling even when info is available because they not understand local system.



Secondly, language remains a key barrier in community participation. The study has shown that language difficulty often becomes an interaction pressure or anxiety. Kuperman (2022) argues that language ability affects how immigrants adapt to the host society, which also shapes their chances of taking part in community. Furthermore, our study also shows that weak language confidence can create social discomfort. This can reduce the actual participation.

A third finding is that familiar social networks play a strong role in activity participation. Many participants said that they are more willing to try a new activity if someone they know go with them. They will feel safer and more comfortable in that case. When the environment fully unfamiliar, they become more careful. Study shows that immigrants often depend on trust, familiar contacts and peer support when they use information. They are more likely to trust known people than the formal systems. Hans (2023) also shows that earlier immigrant often help newer immigrants by sharing their own experience. Familiar networks not only pass on information. They also reduce uncertainty and make it easier for families to enter new social spaces.

Last is information about community activities is still fragmented. These sources include schools, parent groups, friends, social media and some official platforms. The survey shows that friends, other parents, and schools are the most common sources and formal platforms are less used. This result suggests that community activity information still moves mainly through informal networks. Some HCI studies already discuss how digital tools can help immigrants understand information. For example, Concilio et al. (2022) use co-design to develop tools that support multilingual understanding and help people deal with administrative systems. Our study supports this line of work. At the same time, our study also show that only language support or information display is still not enough. Platform also needs to help users judge activities, reduce uncertainty or build trust.

This study also has some limitations. First, the interview sample is quite small. We recruit participants through our own social networks and Chinese community connections. This means that the findings may not represent all immigrant families. Second, most participants are Chinese immigrant parents. Because of this, the findings are more relevant to Chinese immigrant families. The findings may not apply in the same way to people from other cultural or language backgrounds. Finally, the survey uses self-reported answers. This means that personal memory, opinion or understanding may affect the data. The survey sample is also not large enough for complex statistical analysis. Even so, this study still has two clear strengths. First, the study uses both interviews and surveys, and the two kinds of data support each other. Second, the study focus on one clear background, which is community activity participation. This makes the findings easier to connect to design ideas.

This study also offers clear directions for design practice. The result shows that future support for immigrant families should not stop at simply activity information collection. A platform that

only lists activities will still not solve problems of understanding, judgment and trust issues. Based on our findings, future design should include clearer activity descriptions, previews of what will happen. Also, some language support, other people's experiences and familiar or peer-based recommendation mechanisms. These ideas also match the needs that appear in the open-ended survey responses.

Overall, this study highlights the importance of decision-making support, trust and social background in information use. These insights inform future HCI design and provide a foundation for develop more effective, user-centered systems for immigrant family.

### Conclusion

This study shows that immigrant families face more than one barrier when join community activities. The main issues include **fragmented Information**, uncertainty about activities, language-related pressure and the reliance on familiar social networks. These problems affect immigrant people's confidence and decisions about participation.

The findings suggest that future support should not only provide information, but also help families understand activities more clearly and feel more confident about join them. Overall, this study highlights the need for more inclusive and supportive ways to connect immigrant families with local community activities.

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